

User-Centered Forms Design Guide

Australian Government Style Manual Standards

Introduction: Designing effective forms is crucial for government service delivery and meeting regulatory compliance. Users interact with forms to access vital services or to fulfill government obligations. Sometimes, a user may act on behalf of another, or a public servant might record responses directly during a survey. Before digitizing any paper-based form, it is necessary to perform rigorous research to understand user and business requirements, verifying if a form is even needed at all.

Understanding User Needs through Research

Successful form design begins with discovering the actual terms and phrases people use when discussing the subject matter, including their language patterns within search engines. Integrating these familiar terms ensures the form is highly discoverable and easier to complete. If user groups are unfamiliar with specific administrative terminology, clear and simple definitions must be provided inline. Always maintain an inclusive, clear, and reassuring tone throughout the transaction.

The 'Question Protocol' & Data Minimisation

A **Question Protocol** is a fundamental governance document developed before form creation. It acts as a gatekeeper to ensure that your organisation only collects information that is strictly necessary. Every question asked imposes an immediate cost in time and cognitive effort on the user, and an operational burden on the organisation managing the data. The question protocol helps designers challenge and push back against redundant requests.

Domain of Inquiry	Critical Questions to Address
Information Value	• Do you actually need this information? Why? • How much detail is required? • Can this data be obtained elsewhere (e.g., existing agency database)?
User Experience	• Which user segments must provide this information? • How will they discover or receive this form? • Will the form require contributions from multiple parties? • What are the user's touchpoints before and after completing the form?

Domain of Inquiry	Critical Questions to Address
Data Management	• How will the accuracy of the responses be verified? • What error prevention and validation messages are required? • How will the collected records be managed, secured, and kept up-to-date?

Regulatory & Legal Compliance: The question protocol and all completed form submissions are considered official administrative records. They must be managed and disposed of in strict compliance with the *Archives Act 1983*. Additionally, handling personal information imposes legal duties under the *Privacy Act 1988* and the *Australian Privacy Principles (APPs)*. Users have an explicit legal right to request access to their collected data under both the *Privacy Act* and the *Freedom of Information Act 1982*.

Structuring Forms for Cognitive Accessibility

The 'One Thing per Page' Principle: Prototyping forms with exactly one piece of information, one decision, or one question per page is highly recommended. For digital platforms, a single question may span multiple fields if it constitutes a single conceptual item (for example, breaking a birthdate into Day, Month, and Year fields, or an address block into multiple text boxes). This design pattern greatly reduces user cognitive load, allows immediate autosaving as users navigate, simplifies tracking through web analytics, and makes complex branching and loop logics manageable on small screens.

Form Design Warning: Avoid Progress Indicators. Adding a progress bar is unnecessary for short forms (five questions or fewer) and often causes major issues in complex forms. Because complex transactions rely on branching and conditional logic (skipping irrelevant pages or looping), designing a progress bar that predicts completion accurately is extremely difficult and often misleads the user.

Task Lists and Verification Mechanisms

For multi-stage, complex transactions, test adding a **Task List** page at the start and a **'Check Your Answers'** page at the end. The initial task list page outlines the tasks involved in the transaction, shows progress status, and allows users to jump directly to incomplete sections. The final summary page displays a comprehensive overview of all responses, enabling users to correct errors and confirm accuracy before formal submission.

Layout Element	Design Standards & Rationale
Single Column	Digital forms must maintain a single-column layout. Avoid multiple columns in both digital and print. Multi-column structures disrupt screen readers, increase cognitive load, and break responsiveness on mobile devices.
Question Numbering	For forms with more than one question, number them. This assists users who must leave and return later, and simplifies support interactions or transitioning between print and digital versions.
Required Fields	Do not mark required questions with asterisks. Because the Question Protocol ensures only necessary questions are asked, assume all fields are mandatory. Mark only the occasional non-essential field as 'Optional'.

Selecting Accessible Form Inputs

Selecting the correct input component is essential for usability, ensuring users with hand control difficulties, tremors, or assistive technologies can easily interact with your service.

User Objective	Recommended Control	Alternative / Critical Rule
Select a single option	Radio Buttons	Must be placed to the left of their labels. Avoid 'select dropdowns' and range sliders.
Select multiple options	Checkboxes	Must be placed to the left of their labels. Renders distinct selections transparently.
Provide written answers	Text Inputs	Input box size must correspond to the expected length of the answer. Never disable input fields.

Form Elements to Avoid

- 1. Select Boxes (Dropdown Menus) & Range Sliders:** These are notoriously difficult to navigate for individuals with motor impairments or essential tremors. Instead of select dropdowns, reduce choice paths or present options as structured radio buttons. Replace range sliders with clear, selectable radio options.
- 2. Disabled Fields & Buttons:** Disabled form components confuse users, who often cannot discern why they are locked or how to activate them. Keep all relevant elements interactive; do not present irrelevant fields at all.
- 3. Placeholder Text:** Never use placeholder text inside an input box. It disappears once clicked, typically possesses poor visual contrast, and confuses screen readers. Write persistent labels and explicit hint text outside the box instead.

Placement of Labels and Help Text

Every question requires a clear, concise label. Do not place a colon at the end of the label. Position the label close to and directly above the question input box. Position any supplementary **Help Text** (hint text) directly between the label and the input box. Do not use interactive 'tooltips' (which appear on hover), as they are inaccessible to screen reader and keyboard-only users. For numerical entries, place standard symbols close to the box (\$ on the left, % on the right).

Validation, Error Prevention & Branding

Validation & Error Recovery: Digital forms must execute validation checks to catch empty entries or formatting errors (such as verifying telephone digits or the presence of an '@' character in emails). When an error occurs, the validation message must be supportive, constructive, and actionable—never blaming the user. Use clear visual cues to highlight errors, but do not rely on color alone to convey meaning, as colorblind users or screen readers might miss them. Status and validation messages should be programmatically associated with their fields to satisfy WCAG AA standards (success criteria 3.3.1, 3.3.3, and 4.1.3).

Handling User Ineligibility

If user input reveals they are ineligible for the service, do not trigger a validation error. Instead, route the user to a dedicated page that clearly explains why they are unable to use the service and presents alternative channels or options.

Save and Resume Functionality: For multi-page or complex transactional forms, provide a prominent 'Save as draft' button. When users return, the form must restore their state and reopen to the precise page where they left off. Upon successful submission, always display a clear confirmation screen with a unique receipt code.

Australian Government Branding & Visuals: All government forms, whether print or digital, must conform strictly to the Australian Government Branding Guidelines regarding logo placement, color usage, and typeface hierarchy. Keep visual elements to a minimum. Do not include decorative icons or images unless research confirms they actively help the user comprehend the form. Make sure all images comply with digital accessibility guidelines.